

CERTIFICATION

Candidate Handbook

For the Certified Transaction Monitoring
Associate Examination



Why Earn CTMA?



Transaction monitoring is a core component of an AML and financial crime compliance program. For individuals, CTMA can help set them apart by certifying their knowledge of transaction monitoring processes. For institutions, certifying employees with CTMA represents a significant commitment to AML and financial crime compliance in a world of increasingly complex laws, regulations, and policies.

Certified Transaction Monitoring Associate (CTMA) is for early career professionals who wish to or are working in transaction monitoring roles, in addition to the people who supervise them or support them. When combined with six to twelve months of experience, an individual with CTMA should be able to investigate an alert from a transaction monitoring system from the point at which it is generated to the point at which it is either cleared or escalated to the team which makes determinations and files suspicious activity reports (SARs). Although technology specialists may wish to take CTMA, the program does not focus in-depth on the associated technology. The technologies that generate TM alerts are covered only at the level of understanding key principles such as thresholds and reasons for false positives.

The role of transaction monitoring in Financial Crime Prevention:

- Types of financial crime related risk
- The purpose of transaction monitoring in the context of the risk-based approach, risk assessment, and risk appetite of an institution
- Specific risks associated with customer types and products
- The beneficial ownership and counter-party checks required in transaction monitoring
- The relationship between transaction monitoring and ongoing due diligence
- Screening transactions versus post-transaction alerts
- How the effectiveness of transaction monitoring processes is measured and quality is assured
- The difference between unusual and suspicious activity

Benefits of CTMA for an organization:

- CTMA applies a consistent standard, enabling an organization to demonstrate its TM workforce has demonstrated an objective and carefully established benchmark of role-based knowledge.
- As a global credential, CTMA enables multinational organizations to apply a single, consistent program across their global network.
- CTMA enables organizations to tap into the diverse, international global network of ACAMS, the world's leading membership organization dedicated to enhancing the knowledge and skills of financial crime prevention professionals.

CTMA Preparation and Support

The CTMA examination requires thorough preparation. But, we are with you every step of the way. Our certification program equips you with everything you need to properly prepare for the exam.

Study Materials

The study guide is your main reference material and content source for preparing for the rigors of the examination. We also offer additional study materials to support you, please visit our website [acams.org](https://www.acams.org) or contact your account manager for more details.

[Contact Us](#) | [ACAMS](#)



About CTMA Certification

About this Handbook

This handbook provides information that you will need to register for the Certified Transaction Monitoring Associate examination including eligibility requirements, policies, and exam blueprint. It also includes the CTMA recertification policies so that you can keep your CTMA certification active and up to date.

CTMA Eligibility Requirements and ACAMS Membership

Candidates wishing to sit for the CTMA examination must have:

- **Active ACAMS membership**

Candidates who pass the CTMA examination and wish to use and display the CTMA credential must have an active ACAMS membership.

Examination Fee

STANDARD CTMA PACKAGE

PRIVATE SECTOR	US\$1,045
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How to Get Started

STEP 1:

Choose your membership and CTMA certification package.

STEP 2:

Submit your payment, application and supporting documents.

STEP 3:

Upon payment, we will provide you with access to the ACAMS LMS where you will find all your preparation material.

STEP 4:

Once your application is approved and your membership and certification payment is complete, you will receive an email from ACAMS to schedule your exam.

About CTMA Certification

How to Apply

Complete your online application and submit payment.

Payment may be made by credit card, personal check, cashier's check, money order or wire transfer (wire transfers must include identifying information). Checks should be made payable to ACAMS. Prices are subject to change. Declined credit cards and/or returned checks are subject to a US\$25 penalty.

Please submit your questions via our [Contact Us](#) page online.

Background Verification Check

ACAMS reserves the right to conduct a background check, including a criminal records check, on all people wishing to take the CTMA examination. Candidates may be required to fill out a Background Verification Authorization Form.

Candidates will receive correspondence from ACAMS regarding the status of their application in the event ACAMS performs a background check.

Please be advised that for the integrity of our association and its mission, in the event an individual is subject to a background check and does not pass, that individual will not be allowed to take the CTMA examination.

Statement of Nondiscrimination

ACAMS does not discriminate among candidates based on age, gender, race, color, religion, national origin, disability or marital status.

Disability Services

ACAMS is committed to providing reasonable accommodations for individuals with documented disabilities as defined by local or applicable law. Our intent is to ensure that everyone who makes a request for accommodations is advised of the accommodation process as promptly as possible. If you have a disability as defined under local or applicable law, please contact our Accommodations Coordinator for a request form and information regarding our accommodation process.

Process:

1. Contact Disability Services Accommodation Coordinator:
E-mail: accommodations@acams.org
Phone: 1.786.456.4705
Fax: 1.866.494.0040
2. The Accommodations Coordinator will provide you an application. Complete the accommodation request form specifying your impairment and the requested accommodation. In addition to the form, you must provide recent (generally no more than five years old) certification and/or documentation from a qualified medical or educational professional that (a) provides a specific diagnosis; and (b) recommends specific accommodations that might be helpful to the applicable setting and request based on the diagnosis.
3. Your request with supporting documentation will be evaluated as appropriate to determine whether your request can reasonably be granted.

If granted, we will coordinate to implement the request. If the request is denied or deemed unreasonable by ACAMS, we will explore any alternative reasonable accommodations options, if appropriate.

Requests are reviewed on an individual and rolling basis. Please note, the time for approval could potentially affect the timeframe for testing with approved accommodation/s. If you believe you have been discriminated against due to a disability you should contact: accommodations-management@acams.org to address the immediate situation.

CTMA Examination

Taking the CTMA Examination

The CTMA examination consists of 60 multiple choice questions. Some of these items are unscored. The unscored items are included on the exam to gather statistical information. These items are not identified on the exam and do not affect your score. All candidates have 90 minutes to complete the exam. To obtain the CTMA credential, candidates must answer a minimum of 74% of the scored questions correctly.

There is no penalty for guessing. Avoid leaving any questions unanswered to maximize your chances of passing. For review questions, please refer to the CTMA Study Guide.

Disclaimer: The review questions contained in the study guide are not meant to indicate the exact style or difficulty level of the actual CTMA examination questions. They are designed to help candidates review the content of the study guide.

CTMA Examination Blueprint

The CTMA examination consists of four domains. Below you will find the test objectives for each of the domains as well as the overall percentage weight of each domain.

I. ROLE OF TRANSACTION MONITORING IN FINANCIAL CRIME PREVENTION 20%

- | | |
|---|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none">1.1 Types of financial crime related risk (e.g., regulatory, legal, financial, and reputational risk; customer, jurisdiction, geography, and channel risk)1.2 The purpose of transaction monitoring in the context of the risk-based approach, risk assessment, and risk appetite of an institution1.3 Specific risks associated with customer types (e.g., non-bank financial institutions, money service bureaus, cash-intensive small businesses, vehicle sellers, etc.), and products (e.g., correspondent banking, money orders, third-party payment processors, pre-paid cards) | <ul style="list-style-type: none">1.4 The beneficial ownership and counter-party checks required in transaction monitoring1.5 The relationship between transaction monitoring and ongoing due diligence, including KYC-CDD, customer profiles, customer risk scores, and anticipated customer behavior1.6 Screening transactions versus post-transaction alerts, including how sanctions and fraud risk are managed1.7 How the effectiveness of transaction monitoring processes is measured and quality is assured (e.g., false-positive rates)1.8 The difference between unusual and suspicious activity |
|---|--|

II. TRANSACTION MONITORING ALERT GENERATION 15%

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|---|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none">2.1 How alerts are generated and different alert sources (e.g. manually prepared reports/human referrals and automated transaction monitoring programs)2.2 How to determine if an alert is valid, including differentiating between valid alerts, false positives, and non-productive alerts2.3 Why the volume of alerts may change over time and how/when to report changes to higher level managers | <ul style="list-style-type: none">2.4 The purpose of scenarios, rules, patterns, behavior bases, and thresholds2.5 The purpose of tuning, the responsible parties (e.g. governance structure) and when it should be conducted, as well as how the alert monitoring process informs tuning activities in the organization |
|---|---|

CTMA Examination *continued*

III. ALERT INVESTIGATION 40%

- 3.1 Money laundering typologies/red flags and associated unusual transaction activity (e.g., structuring, transaction with no apparent economic, business, or lawful purpose, suspicious wire transfers)
- 3.2 Terrorist financing typologies/red flags and associated unusual transaction activity (e.g., charities and non-profits, diamonds, precious metals, antiquities)
- 3.3 Non-AML financial crime typologies/red flags and associated unusual transaction activity (e.g., fraud, sanctions, tax evasion, and bribery/corruption)
- 3.4 How to investigate multiple alerts by an individual customer (e.g., multiple alerts generated for one transaction monitoring period related to the same customer)
- 3.5 The research steps involved in transaction monitoring investigations (e.g., obtaining and reviewing KYC-CDD information, reviewing the case management system, checking internal sources, looking at transaction data related to the alerts, and reviewing linked counter-parties and accounts)
- 3.6 Best practices for gathering additional information (e.g., contacting a customer as part of an investigation, submitting a request for information (RFI), and conducting public searches)
- 3.7 Common mistakes in transaction monitoring (e.g., not considering the source of the data and using out of date records in the review process)
- 3.8 How to identify new risks during transaction monitoring investigations

IV. OUTCOMES OF TRANSACTION MONITORING INVESTIGATIONS 25%

- 4.1 Outcomes of the transaction monitoring investigation (e.g., alert closure, alert closure with CDD update or other recommendation, escalation, recommended SAR filing)
- 4.2 How to document rationales for decisions and create an audit trail (e.g. for regulators, future law enforcement inquiries, assurance and audit teams)
- 4.3 Regulatory requirements associated with reporting suspicious and/or unusual activity (e.g., MLRO responsibility, when process begins, time period for filing, agency for reporting) and criteria for manually escalating an alert to a case
- 4.4 The reasons for which activity should be escalated for a potential SAR filing, the confidentiality of SARs (e.g., tipping off), and what occurs after a SAR is filed
- 4.5 Notifications from FIU/law enforcement, including requests to close account or maintain normal business activity, dealing with repeat SARs, etc.

CERTIFIED
CTMA[™]

TRANSACTION MONITORING
ASSOCIATE

What You Need Before The Exam With Pearson VUE



Reschedule/Cancellation Policy Regarding Your Exam Date

Refunds will not be granted to individuals requesting to withdraw from an exam after registering. You can reschedule or cancel on the web up to 72 hours before the exam at no charge. You can also reschedule or cancel via the Pearson VUE call center (+1 866-389-8339) up to 72 hours before the exam for a fee of US\$20.

If you cancel or reschedule an exam within 24 to 72 hours of your scheduled time, there will be a fee of US\$100 collected by Pearson VUE. There is an additional fee for scheduling an exam by phone rather than by using the online system. Pearson VUE call centers will answer questions for assisting with online scheduling free of charge. However, if the exam is scheduled on the phone, there will be a US\$20 fee collected by Pearson VUE.

If you cancel your exam within 24 hours or do not show up for your scheduled appointment, you will need to contact ACAMS and you will be charged for a new authorization (US\$299 private sector/ US\$199 public sector).

Examination Day

Plan to arrive/login 30 minutes before the scheduled appointment to allow time for check-in. Candidates who are late may not be allowed to test.

Identification

Bring with you two forms of current and valid government-issued identification bearing a photograph and a signature. The name on the identification must match the name used for registration.

Identification (ID) Requirements:

- The first and last name that the candidate uses to register must match exactly the first and last name on both of the IDs that are presented on test day.
- All IDs required must be issued by the country/region in which the candidate is testing. If the candidate does not have a qualifying primary ID issued from the country/region they are testing in, an International Travel Passport from their country/region of citizenship is required, along with a secondary ID.
- Candidate is required to present two forms of original (no photo copies or digital IDs), valid (unexpired) IDs; one form as a primary ID (government issued with name, recent recognizable photo, and signature) and one form as a secondary ID (with at least a name and signature, or name and recent recognizable photo).

Additional ID Allowances:

- Expired forms of ID are not acceptable unless accompanied by valid renewal papers.
- For candidates testing in Japan, please click on the [link](#) for Japan ID policy.
- If a government issued ID is missing a visible signature (or has an embedded signature), the candidate is allowed to test as long as the other requirements for primary and secondary IDs are met.
- If you have any questions about the ID you are required to bring with you to the testing center for admittance for your exam, please contact Pearson VUE customer service at <http://www.pearsonvue.com/acams/contact>. Any candidate exceptions to the ID policy must be pre-approved by the Pearson VUE customer service center at least three business days before the scheduled exam appointment.

What You Need Before The Exam With Pearson VUE *continued*

Examination Integrity/ Professional Dishonesty

The examination performance of all candidates is monitored and may be analyzed statistically for purposes of detecting and verifying any form of cheating. Candidates are also advised that they cannot disclose Exam Materials, including questions or answers. This includes discussing the content of the exam with anyone, recording, copying, or disclosing any exam question or answer, in whole or in part, directly or indirectly, in any form or by any means whatsoever (this includes "chat rooms", message boards, forums, etc.) If it is determined that a score has questionable validity, after appropriate review, the score will be marked as invalid and the candidate may be barred from retesting indefinitely or for a period as determined by ACAMS.

Examination Procedures and Code of Conduct

Additional time will not be allowed. There are no scheduled breaks. Candidates must have the permission of the proctor to leave the testing room.

No questions concerning the content of the exam may be asked during the testing period. It is the responsibility of each candidate to read the directions given on the computer and listen carefully to the instructions given by the proctor.

The proctor reserves the right to dismiss a candidate from the examination for any of the following reasons:

1. If the candidate's admission to the exam is unauthorized.
2. If a candidate creates a disturbance, is abusive or is otherwise uncooperative.
3. If a candidate gives or receives help or is suspected of doing so.
4. If a candidate attempts to remove examination materials or notes from the testing room.
5. If a candidate is discovered in possession of an electronic communication or recording device.

Confidentiality

Candidates receive their exam results immediately (pass or fail) at the conclusion of the test. Results will not be given over the telephone, by facsimile, or electronic mail. When an organization pays for an individual's examination, the organization may request ACAMS to release the result to the organization. If a candidate does not want this information to be released to the organization, then the candidate must notify ACAMS in writing.

ACAMS posts a [list](#) of certified members.

To schedule a re-take, the candidate must:

1. Request an invoice through the [Contact Us](#) page online.
2. Pay the examination fee for their new Authorization to Test. US\$199 for Private members.
3. Reschedule their exam through the test delivery website.

Appeals

ACAMS provides an appeal mechanism for challenging denial of admission to the exam or revocation of the certification. It is the responsibility of the individual to initiate the appeal process by written request to ACAMS within 30 days of the circumstance leading to the appeal.

Please note: Failure of the exam does not constitute grounds for a review and appeal.

What You Need Before The Exam With Pearson VUE *continued*

Data and Privacy Policies

To read through Pearson VUE's data and privacy policies please visit <https://home.pearsonvue.com/privacy>.

Pearson VUE Demo

If you would like a preview of the Pearson VUE computer-based testing platform, [click here](#) to launch the demo. It includes information about question types and the user interface so that you can become familiar with it prior to taking your exam.

Integrity of the Examination

ACAMS has taken strict security measures to ensure the integrity of the CTMA examination. These security measures include:

Proctors — There will be examination proctors present before, during, and after the examination to ensure that all rules and regulations are followed.

Video Cameras — There are high-tech video cameras surrounding the examination site of every testing center to ensure that no assistance is given during the examination.

Audio — There is a live audio recording of each examination session to ensure that no assistance is given during the examination.

Retaking the Examination

If a candidate does not pass, they will have the opportunity to retake the examination. Candidates can retake the exam after 30 days.

TEST CENTER

ITEMS NOT PERMITTED

No personal items, including but not limited to mobile phones, hand-held computers/personal digital assistants (PDAs) or other electronic devices, pagers,

watches, wallets, purses, firearms or other weapons, hats (and other non-religious head coverings), bags, coats, jackets, eyeglass cases, pens, or pencils, are allowed in the testing room. No barrettes or hair clips that are larger than 1/4 inch (1/2 centimeter) wide and headbands or hairbands that are larger than 1/2 inch (1 centimeter) wide are allowed in the testing room. No jewelry that is removable and larger than 1/4 inch (1/2 centimeter) wide is allowed in the testing room. No books and/or notes are allowed in the testing room unless authorized by the test program sponsor for your use during the test. You must store all personal items in a secure area as indicated by the test administrator or return them to your vehicle. If you refuse to store your personal items, you will be unable to test, and you will lose your test fee. All electronic devices must be turned off before storing them in the designated secure area.

CENTER PROBLEM REPORTING

If there are any irregularities during the examination process, the proctor at each testing center will fill out a Center Problem Report which records the exact details of the irregular incident.

INCLEMENT WEATHER

In the event of inclement weather or unforeseen emergencies on the day of an exam, ACAMS will determine whether circumstances warrant cancellation and subsequent rescheduling of an exam. Every attempt will be made to administer all exams as scheduled. However, should an exam be canceled at a test center, all scheduled candidates will be contacted and receive notification regarding a rescheduled date or reapplication instructions.

HOME OR OFFICE

ONLINE PROCTORING

ACAMS may be offering online proctoring at your home or office for candidates taking their certification in certain locations. Test Taker must read the [FAQ](#) for Online Proctored Exam's limitations and restrictions.

CTMA Recertification Policies

The purpose of the CTMA recertification process is to ensure that Certified Transaction Monitoring Associates continue to maintain and enhance their expertise. Therefore, CTMA professionals are required to earn recertification credits through training.

Recertification Requirements

In order to recertify the CTMA credential, you must meet the following requirements:

1. Maintain an active ACAMS membership.
2. A total of two (2) credits must be accumulated and must be earned from ACAMS provided training.

Membership Status

Recertification applicants must maintain an active ACAMS membership over the one-year period in order to recertify.

ACAMS Credits

ACAMS Credits are earned from ACAMS-hosted activities such as virtual classrooms, webinars, events, chapter, certificates, and certifications. These are tracked and added automatically to our members' profiles.

Non-ACAMS Credits

These are earned from any source other than ACAMS. These are not added automatically to members' profiles. Instead, members are responsible for providing their proof of participation to ACAMS. The criteria for an external activity to count for non-ACAMS credits is outlined below:

- Be related to the subject matter; AFC – AML/CTF, Sanctions, etc.
- Meet a minimum of one hour of continuous learning.
- Provide proof of participation after completion. All documentation submitted to ACAMS needs to clearly state the participant's name, the training's title, date, and the number of credits.
- Be completed before the end of the recertification cycle.
- The activity must be synchronous. No asynchronous activities will be accepted.

Recertification Cycle

The recertification cycle is the one-year period from the time an individual receives their certification or from the date of their most recent recertification.



Notes

Contact Us

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